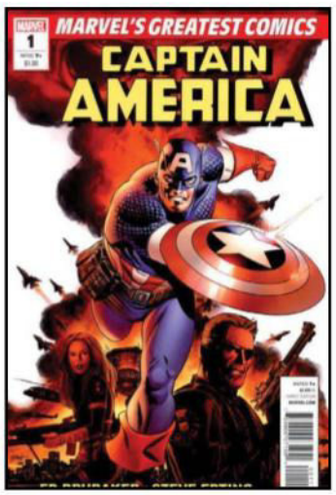


CAPTAIN AMERICA IS THE MOST FAMOUS PATRIOT, BUT HE WASN'T THE FIRST. WE BURROW INTO THE HEART OF THE AMERICAN COMIC-BOOK HERO, FROM WARTIME PROPAGANDA TO POST-WAR JINGOSIM, AND DISCOVER WHY CAPTAIN AMERICA HAS OUTLASTED HIS PEERS...

When it comes to eye-catching images on the newsstands, nothing quite beats a red, white and blue-bedecked superhero punching out Hitler. It's one of the most visceral covers in comics history, and with that iconic blow, Captain America joined World War II a full 12 months before the attack on Pearl Harbor, at a time when most of the US was ambivalent at best about entering the combat.

Captain America, aka Steve Rogers, appeared in his own series in 1940 at Marvel Comics (then called Timely). The creation of Joe Simon and Jack Kirby, Rogers knew his duty was to serve his country, and that meant enlisting in the service at any cost, despite his various physical ailments.

However, good ol' Cap was not the first hero to embody American patriotism. In January 1940, many months prior to Captain America's debut, Archie Comics (then MLJ) introduced *The Shield*, the alter-ego of Joe Higgins, who took his father's super-strength formula and became a superhero (yes, there is some similarity with Cap there – apparently back then superheroes had to share origin stories). Meanwhile, Superman, although technically Kryptonian, had been embraced as an icon of the American dream, standing, as we all know for truth, justice and the American way, and in her role as Ambassador to America, Wonder Woman took on the country's colours and ideology.

Others, such as Mr America, Ms America, Ms Victory, The Eagle, Phantom Eagle, Captain Flag, Yankee Girl, US Jones, Patriot, Yank & Doodle, Fighting Yank and V-Man joined the ranks of heroes with a predilection for wearing an American flag (luckily, most of them came from different comic universes, otherwise the weekly hero meetings could have been very confusing for a while). Jason Dittmer, author of *Captain America And The Nationalist Superhero: Metaphors, Narratives And Geopolitics*, brings up past icons of national identity, pointing out that "ideas like 'Britain' or 'America' are so complex – all those people, all those institutions – that they need to be reduced down to a metaphor." He draws comparisons between the likes of Lady Liberty and Britannia, and superheroes of the Forties who took on the mantle of national identity.

There is another factor in the number of patriotic heroes. During the late Thirties and early Forties, many Jewish writers and creators had turned to the comics industry for employment, since at the time other publishing careers such as advertising were effectively closed to them. They frequently took conventionally American names as a way to 'become' American – you're probably familiar with Bob Kane as the creator of Batman, but his parents knew him as Robert Kahn, while Jacob Kurtzberg went through a few names before deciding on Jack Kirby. Many people have pointed out the close link ⇨





By the time the US entered World War II in 1941, patriotic superheroes were a dime a dozen.

"JACK KIRBY AND JOE SIMON KNEW THE NAZIS WERE THE BAD GUYS WELL BEFORE THE REST OF AMERICA MADE UP ITS MIND"
JASON DITTMER